Oct. 2022 A nine-member Cheetah Task Force is announced to make decisions about cheetahs' management

Sept. 2022 The first lot of eight cheetahs arrives at Kuno Palpur from Namibia. An MoU is to be signed with South Africa to get more cheetahs

Jul. 2022 India and Namibia sign a memorandum of understanding for bringing in cheetahs from that country



ANI

Nov. 2022 In a staggered manner, all eight cheetahs are moved from quarantine to a larger, game-stocked enclosure

Jan. 2023 Female Sasha shows signs of renal distress, brought back in quarantine for treatment



ANI

Feb. 2023 Twelve cheetahs, seven male and five female, come to KNP from South Africa

Aug. 2024 In the 13th and latest casualty, Pawan from Namibia dies due to suspected drowning

Aug. 2023 All 14 cheetahs are brought back to the enclosures where they are kept presently pending release after the monsoons

May 2023 Environment ministry announces setting up of an 11-member Cheetah Project Steering Committee–over and above the Cheetah Task Force announced in October 2022

Mar. 2023 Two Namibian cheetahs are released into the wild. Sasha dies, marking the first casualty among Namibian cheetahs. Four cubs are born to Siyaya at the park

MP FOREST DEPT'S ANNUAL REPORT FLAGS A HUGE DEFICIT OF PREY IN KUNO. IT CALLS FOR IMMEDIATE PREY AUGMENTATION. AT LEAST 1,500 CHITAL NEED TO BE BROUGHT IN

HOW TO PREVENT THE CAT-ASTROPHE

So, after two years of multiple failed attempts to release the cheetahs into the wild, will this be a turning point? What more needs to be done? "As a first step towards metapopulation management through a large landscape approach, including the landscapes of Kuno and Gandhi Sagar in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and possibly Uttar Pradesh, an interstate cheetah conservation complex is being developed. Here, the forested area spans ~17,000 sq. km with a potential cheetah habitat of ~10,000 sq. km," Yadav says. According to him, there are other potential sites such as Nauradehi (MP) and Banni grasslands (Kutch, Gujarat) etc. "The CAP recommends metapopulation management with three to five sites for long-term persistence of cheetahs in India. Eventually, more potential sites in central and southern India will also be assessed," he says.

In the first phase at Gandhi Sagar, a maximum of four to five cheetahs are likely to be released, providing them an opportunity to establish a breeding population. In Banni, the minister says, "raising enclosures, quarantine boma, veterinary facility and related infrastructure are under progress. Once complete, the steering committee will examine proposals to bring cheetahs for conservation breeding." The earlier plan was to treat the population in Kuno as the source population to translocate a few cheetahs to Gandhi Sagar and Banni, but it seems to have been abandoned. As Gopal indicates, the two new sites will have cheetahs likely to be imported from Kenya and South Africa. "Negotiations are going on with Kenya. The draft MoU to be signed has already been approved by the MoEFCC," says Yadav. Though no timeline has been specified, sources say the third batch could be imported before the end of this year.

Kenyan and South African cheetahs belong to two different subspecies. Gopal says introducing a cheetah subspecies from a northern hemisphere country (Kenya) is desirable for genetic vigour as the cheetah has passed through an "evolutionary bottleneck". However, Jhala says that both cannot be used for introduction in the same region. "It is against the IUCN guidelines.... This will compromise the Indian commitment to global cheetah conservation efforts." Gopal doesn't think so. "They may mate in the future...no issues...uterus size etc. are similar with minor variations owing to geographical isolation," he says.

Biologists have also flagged the concern that Gandhi Sagar and Banni are small fenced enclosures akin to safari parks. Chellam says it is not in keeping with the CAP's original aims and India's conservation ethos of having free-range cheetahs performing their ecological role. Jhala says that fencing was only meant for quarantine purposes and soft release, lasting a couple of months. Gopal too says